

SELF-LOADING PISTOLS

When Maxim's patents on the mechanism of the recoil-operated machine-gun expired, firearms designers began applying the same principle to pistols. The first successful attempt, by Borchardt, actually copied Maxim's breaking-toggle locking system, but his followers found new ways of locking breech and barrel together in such a way that the recoil generated when a round was fired separated the two, allowing the breech to open and the spent cartridge to be expelled. The breech then rebounded against a spring, chambering a fresh round, cocking the action, and leaving the pistol ready to be fired in the process. This cycle took just a fraction of a second.



► WEBLEY-FOSBERY MODEL 1903

Date 1896–1924

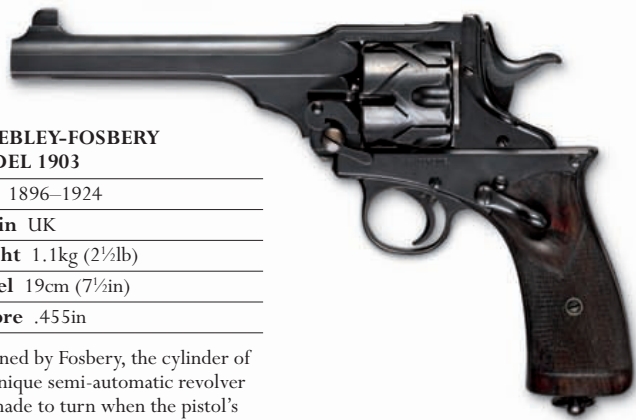
Origin UK

Weight 1.1kg (2½lb)

Barrel 19cm (7½in)

Calibre .455in

Designed by Fosbery, the cylinder of this unique semi-automatic revolver was made to turn when the pistol's upper frame was driven back by recoil and returned by a spring.



► GABBETT-FAIRFAX "MARS"

Date 1899–1902

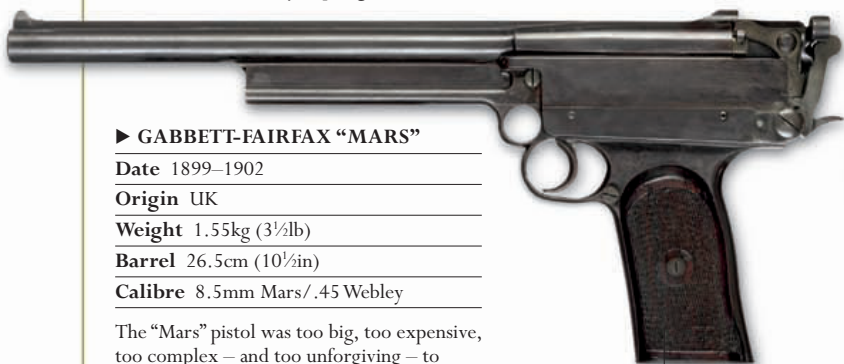
Origin UK

Weight 1.55kg (3½lb)

Barrel 26.5cm (10½in)

Calibre 8.5mm Mars/.45 Webley

The "Mars" pistol was too big, too expensive, too complex – and too unforgiving – to succeed in the already congested and competitive weapon market of 1900.



Butt houses removable seven-round magazine



► STEYR M1905

Date 1905–15

Origin Austria-Hungary

Weight 940g (33¼oz)

Barrel 16cm (6½in)

Calibre 7.63mm Mannlicher

The Mannlicher-designed M1905 was chambered for a round generally thought too powerful for a "blowback" action, but succeeded – although it was never especially popular – due to the high standard to which it was manufactured.

Recoil spring housing

